

ANOTHER HEARTBREAK FOR INDIA AT FIFAE WORLD CUP

India's best hope **Danial Patel**, aka DaNiAL, lost to MINBAPPE in the quarterfinals

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Danial Patel, aka DaNiAL, has been one of India's best hopes in KONAMI eFootball over the last two years. His quick passing, lightning reflexes, and composure on the phone have seen him wear the Indian jersey for esports even before he turned 18.

Last year, he reached the semifinals of the first FIFAE World Cup featuring eFootball-Mobile, beating esports powerhouses Japan and Indonesia. But in the semifinals, he faced Muhaimin Ahmad — aka MINBAPPE — of Malaysia.

MINBAPPE was Malaysia's best eFootball player, and the impediment proved too much for a younger Indian competitor, as DaNiAL lost 2-3, missing out on a historic medal. MINBAPPE went on to win the tournament.

A year later, history repeated itself, yet again in an agonising fashion: MINBAPPE won the first match 0-3 against DaNiAL and then won the next game 2-1. The contest ended 2-0, and India's dream run ended yet again, this time in the quarterfinals.

MINBAPPE, however, could not emulate his triumphant campaign this time around as eventual champion Jomkata JXMKT Yupraphat of Thailand beat him in the semifinals. JXMKT, playing for the esports wing of Thailand's most successful top-flight club, Buriram United, beat Malaysia and then Brazil – José Antonio 'JUNINHO' Maciel Junior – to clinch the title.

On the console, Poland – represented by Milosz 'Zilo' Zietek and Mikolaj 'Ostrybuch' Zietek — was crowned world champion, beating Italy in the final.

An esports champion at 92!

Esports, for the longest time, has been branded as a sport for the young. But Hisako Sakai of Japan broke the

stereotype with authority.
Last month, Hisako participated in Tekken 8 in the 12th Care Esports Cup and came out on top. Her age? 92 years!

The tournament, organised by Care Esports Association, is a Japanese organisation that brings competitive gaming to an older generation, helping care home residents between the ages of 60-90 keep their minds healthy through esports.

Since the tournament was invitational, Sakai's win is unlikely to take the crown from the officially recognised oldest Esports champion, which belongs to Abbe Borg, who, at 78, was part of the team that won the DreamHack CS: GO seniors tournament in 2019.

Initial schedule announced for BGIS 2026

Krafton India has announced the registration dates for the fifth edition of its BGMI tournament, the Battlegrounds Mobile India Series (BGIS) 2026, set to begin on December 15.

Scheduled to run from January to March 2026, BGIS will feature a larger format this time, along with a prize pool of Rs. 2 crore.

Key dates for BGIS 2026

Registrations Open: December 15, 2025

Registrations Close: January 4, 2026

Registration Data Verification: January 5-7, 2026

In-Game Qualifiers: January 8-14, 2026

"In 2026, our goal is to elevate Indian esports by creating a system that is more inclusive, more aspirational, and more deeply connected to the millions of players who have supported BGMI over the years," Karan Pathak, associate director of sports, Krafton India, said.